

CHAPTER SIX

Montevideo, Uruguay

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RETURN TO HEADQUARTERS

PART ONE

Upon my return to Headquarters I was assigned to be the Deputy Chief of SR/2. This component of the SR(Soviet Russia) Division was responsible for providing Hqs. support and guidance for all activities against the Baltic States (viz. Lithuania, Latvia, and Estonia.) It was a natural follow-up to part of the activity in which I was engaged while in Munich. The branch was rather large, consisting as I recall of about 35-40 people- most of whom had had extensive experience in Baltic operations and some of whom were of Baltic origin themselves. The major thing which I remember from this assignment was an action which I took while serving as Acting Branch Chief for about six weeks while the Branch Chief was touring various field stations. A senior officer (GS-14) had violated some specific instructions which I had given to him on a trip he took to Europe in connection with an Estonian operation. Without getting into the details of what happened, I was able to verify by written memorandum what I had said and done and the results were extremely important in a personnel action which was taken against the man two years later.

As a result of my demonstrated ability to manage a branch, I was assigned in the summer of 1955 to be Chief of SR/5, responsible for operational activity against the Soviets in the entire Far Eastern area- from Japan to Southeast Asia. I was also promoted to grade GS-13 (equivalent to a Lt. Colonel.) Since this was a very extensive area and my only association with the Far East had been a war time one in the Navy, I had to tour the stations involved and become familiar first hand with their personnel and their operational activities. I took this tour just two weeks after I had been put in the bishopric of the Alexandria Ward and was away for almost six weeks. First stop was Tokyo, Japan where the majority of the anti-Soviet operations were taking place. I stayed there for two weeks, then, along with the chief of the Tokyo SR component, continued on to Hongkong, Singapore, Bangkok, and Rangoon. My traveling companion, Jacques Richardson, returned to Tokyo and I continued my trip around the world since I was already more than half-way around, stopping in Beirut, Lebanon and Athens, Greece.

In Athens I became deathly sick from a bug apparently picked up on a previous stop. Fortunately, our good friends, the Parkers, were still stationed in Athens. Initially they sent me out to the U. S. Air Force dispensary to determine whether or not I had contracted hepatitis. Then they took care of me for a period of five days.

After leaving Athens I went to Rome for a visit with that station and then returned home pretty worn out.

Having been gone on my round-the-world trip for six weeks, I was almost a stranger in the Alexandria Ward when I returned. The first time that I went to church after returning someone greeted me at the door to introduce himself and I had somewhat reluctantly had to tell him that I was member of the bishopric who had left only a couple of weeks after having been put in. In mid-1956 the bishopric was reorganized again because the Bishop, Joe Dunn, was being transferred out of the Washington area. A young lawyer named Nad Peterson was put in as the bishop and I was the first counselor, with LeRoy Walker, an Army Lt. Colonel, as the second counselor. W. Theral O'Bryant, Willard D. Hagey and Kent Crowther were the clerks. We have maintained a close friendship with the O'Bryants since that time.

One historical note of interest for the year 1955 is that it was in this year that Jonas Salk developed a successful vaccine against polio, a disease which we feared so much in my youth and had still left its crippling effects on far too many people, particularly young children and teenagers. In the summer of 1956, having been encouraged by Radio Liberation to do something about their Soviet masters, the Hungarian people revolted against the Soviet presence. This was a particularly difficult period in U.S-Soviet relations and instead of helping out the Hungarians (who, of course, expected the United States to come to their aid) Eisenhower opted to avoid a confrontation with the Soviets. As a result about 100,000 Hungarians perished and many hundreds of thousands more became refugees. Our program to try to influence disaffection in the Satellite countries went down the drain and has never recovered.

Being in the bishopric as well as serving as a Branch Chief at the Agency were pretty demanding on my time so we didn't get far from Alexandria, Virginia until late summer of 1956 when we drove out to Utah for a brief spell and then went on up through Idaho and into Yellowstone Park. At that time one could still find bears and wildlife close to the camps and the cars and we have several photos of some bears, taken safely from the windows of the car.

Our first child, Ronald, was baptized in the spring of 1957 in the Washington, D.C. chapel. He was about the age for going on the Father's and Son's outings which were held on a Stake basis in one of the many forested parks in Virginia. Unfortunately, we spent a lot of time overseas during these important years. Having been back from the field for a year and a half, I was anxious to get back out again. Insofar as I could I always tried to chose my operational assignments so that my family would have the benefit of a good church relationship, so when an opportunity came to go to Uruguay, I jumped at it, there

being a strong mission in that country. In addition the operational activity seemed to be advantageous since Uruguay had just recently re-established diplomatic relations with the Soviet Union. Since mid-1955 our operational thrust was two-fold in nature, firstly, to try to infiltrate the Soviet Union via a legal traveler, code name REDSKIN, program, instead of clandestine overflights or other illegal entry programs, and secondly, to help countries with whom the Soviets were establishing relations in their counter-intelligence efforts. We also had a program, called REDCAP, to try, through direct contact or through third-nationals, to recruit official Soviet personnel living abroad.

PART TWO

After studying some Spanish part-time for only about six weeks in the late summer of 1957, we were assigned to the Soviet Section of our station in Montevideo, Uruguay. We left New York on the S.S. Brazil, a luxury liner of the Moore-McCormack lines. It was a two week trip and very enjoyable. The kids all had a ball although Patty was still only three and a half years old. Our family went through the traditional "shellback" initiation at the time that we crossed the equator. I had done this previously during my naval service but my initiation card was in our ocean freight along with the rest of our furniture, so I had to do it again, however, it was pretty mild compared to the one in the Navy.

Shortly before we arrived in Uruguay, the news reported that the Soviets had won the race into space, with the successful launching and orbiting of a device known as the Sputnik, about the size of a basketball. This event galvanized the United States into action. We realized the military implications of such an activity and throughout the next decade there were constant launchings of sub-orbital and manned orbital flights. These activities enabled us to overtake the Soviets and successfully place men on the moon in 1969.

Before we disembarked from the S.S. Brazil, we were visited on board by Robert E. Wells and his wife, Myrle, and by President Arthur Jensen of the Uruguayan Mission, and his wife, Geniel, calling me to serve as a counselor to Bob Wells in the presidency of one of the branches in Montevideo. I never did find out how they knew I was coming but they only said that they had their sources. Bob Wells worked for the First National City Bank of New York and was soon to be transferred to Paraguay. Uruguayan members were still lacking in leadership experience so whenever someone came from the States they were utilized wherever they could be of service. The branch we were in was called Maronias and it met in a dingy rented building in a poorer section of town. Of course, we were able to rent a house in a fashionable district called Carrasco on Andres Puyol 1610.

We became quite good friends with Bob and Myrle Wells and took a trip with them to Buenos Aires, Argentina in their private airplane, a Cessna 180. This was the aircraft in which Bob and his family had earlier flown from the United States to Argentina over the Andes and their flight was written up in an aviation magazine. Small craft like that just didn't fly at the altitude required to cross the Andes.

In March, 1958 the Wells' were transferred to Paraguay and I was made the president of the Maronias Branch with a couple of local brothers as my counselors. One of them, Hermano Rodrigues, demonstrated an act of faith which was particularly poignant to me. I had given him some money from the budget to buy some paint for the chapel. A week or so went by and I hadn't seen nor heard a word from him (there were, of course, no such things as telephones for most people). I went out to his humble quarters to see him, only to find out that they were in such dire economic straits that he didn't have bus fare nor had the family had money to buy food. He also told me that he had been unable to get the paint yet and reached in his pocket and pulled out the money that I had given to him for that purpose. In spite of his dire circumstances he wasn't about to touch the money that belonged to the Lord. A short time later, the administrative officer of the Embassy happened to mention that he was looking for a local to help do some janitorial work around the Embassy and after I told him about Brother Rodrigues and his honesty he hired him for the job.

During our tour in Montevideo I was under cover as a Second Secretary of the Embassy and as such was on the list to attend official receptions. We were always on call for that purpose and it also fit in with our operational purposes of wanting to meet foreign nationals as well as Soviet officials, particularly those whom we knew to be members of the K.G.B. On April 28, 1958 we attended a reception at the Embassy residence in honor of Vice-President and Mrs. Richard M. Nixon.

While generally pleasant living, tours overseas do have their perils and complications and in Uruguay just as we had in Germany our house was broken into and robbed. This time it was while we were at Sacrament meeting at the Maronias Branch. We came home to find the rear persiana (shutter) forced and much of the house, particularly the bedrooms a shambles. We lost such things as radios and jewelry, some of which Marion had inherited from her "Aunt Lucille." In our scrapbook is a newspaper account of the robbery, which, of course, is quite hilarious and shows how wrong and how dramatic the reporters like to elaborate on things. For example, some of the items listed as stolen were "diez encendideros de plata" (ten gold cigarette lighters)-a pretty imaginative account by the reporter.

In August 1958 I took a short TDY to the States to go over the details of an operation in which we were engaged involving the Minister of Interior of Uruguay as being possibly a Soviet agent of influence. It was too detailed and complicated and overrun with political consequences to try to handle by cable and dispatch communications. We eventually arrived at a course of action to take some definitive photos of this man's contact with the KGB resident in Montevideo. We were able to do this with a pin-hole camera arrangement in a package which my agent set down in a cafe on a table next to the conversation and during which money changed hands. It was all to no avail, however, because the Uruguayan government just thought it was too hot of a potato to handle.

This was just one example of the frustrations of my tour in Uruguay which was interesting professionally but not particularly successful. I was responsible for working against the Soviet target, primarily in a counterespionage capacity to help out the Uruguayans. Many of the South American countries had cut off diplomatic relations with the U.S.S.R during the late 1930's and early 1940's as protest of the aggressive takeover of the Baltic States (Lithuania, Latvia, and Estonia.) Following the end of WWII the Latin American states started gradually to resume diplomatic relations and Uruguay was one of them.

The war had made a tremendous impact on many countries and Uruguay, although not a belligerent, was one of them which was severely impacted economically. During the war there was a great demand for Uruguayan wool which was long-stapled and ideal for making uniforms. Consequently, Uruguay concentrated on its wool production by building up its sheep herds and letting its cattle production deteriorate. Of course, after the war was over the demand for wool practically ceased to exist, not only because of the drop in demand for wool for uniforms but also because of the development of synthetic fabrics. Uruguay was thus caught between a rock and a hard place. It had let its cattle production go to pot in favor of sheep and it takes quite a few years to build up herds of cattle again to the point where they can be slaughtered for beef. The economy of Uruguay was thus very much on the down swing. Another factor adversely affecting it was the socialistic nature of the country which permitted its workers to retire on full salaries at the age of fifty. The country was thus pretty ripe for exploitation.

In the early 1950's the Soviets started to build up their representation, particularly with their intelligence officers. My job was to counter the Soviet effort to subvert Uruguayan institutions as well as to determine the vulnerability of the Soviet personnel for working in behalf of U. S. Intelligence. We worked closely with Uruguayan authorities, since our effort was not against Uruguay but

was designed to help that country maintain itself as a democratic state. The leftist element grew rapidly and there was a large active Communist Party in Uruguay, in spite of our efforts and to a large measure because Uruguayans themselves could not or would not believe that certain of their top officials were collaborating with the Soviets, as in the case of the Minister of Interior mentioned above.

Also many so-called students were sent clandestinely to the Soviet Union by leftist groups. At Patrice Lamumba University in Moscow they were trained in guerilla tactics and other "activist" programs. That these programs were successful is evidenced by subsequent events in Uruguay. Terrorist groups became more and more active and caused a great deal of disruption in the Uruguayan economy. Kidnappings of key personnel of business and government were part of their modus operandi. Although it did not occur while we were there, several U. S. businessmen and a government official from the Agency for International Development were held for ransom and political blackmail. Eventually a strong military coup took place to curb the leftist influence and accordingly a lot of ordinary civil rights and democratic institutions went by the wayside. We became cognizant of the student activists due to some mail intercept operations we conducted with certain key individuals of the Uruguayan police. As a result of letters which we were able to intercept and open we knew who many of these potential terrorists were but unfortunately, the difference between knowing who they were and catching up with them when they returned to Uruguay was a different matter.

The C.I.A. Station Chief in Montevideo during my tour there was a well-known writer of mystery thrillers, E. Howard Hunt. He was a very independent guy and got in quite a bit of trouble with the U. S. ambassador because of his many attempts to go around him. Hunt later became "famous" as one of the principle figures in the Watergate case and served some time in prison because of it. I always had fairly good relations with him during my tour and even took over from him as acting station chief once when he had to go to the hospital for a bad case of bleeding ulcers.

In November of 1958, Rhoda Jones, Marion's mother came to stay a few months with us. Marion's father had died in 1956 prior to our assignment to Uruguay. Rhoda traveled to Uruguay with the mother of the Mission president's wife and were a good team together. We took another trip to Buenos Aires, Argentina while she was visiting us. Our good friends, Stewart and Dottie Burton, were stationed in Argentina at that time.

In the spring of 1959 we were honored with a visit by one of the twelve apostles, Spencer W. Kimball and his wife.

He had surgery on his larynx only about six months previously and talked quite hoarsely but the Uruguayan people really loved him. We had him and his wife, Camilla, for dinner at our house, as well as the Jensens and the Schofields, another L.D.S. couple at the station. Of special importance was a trip we took with him to dedicate a chapel in a little out-of-the way place called Isla Patrulla. In order to get there we had to leave our regular cars at a town called Treinta y Tres and travel by an old rickety bus along what couldn't be called a road bed (that's why we couldn't take our cars.) The activities at Isla Patrulla, on the Saturday before the dedication consisted of an asado to which all the people of the village were invited, member and non-member. Amongst the delicacies was "asado con cuero" i.e. roasted mutton and beef with the hide left on one side. Sister Kimball was reluctant to dig into it but Elder Kimball advised her to participate in order not to offend the natives. I sat on the stand with Elder Kimball trying to translate for him but I always have to watch the speaker face to face in order to understand what is going on myself.

At any rate he got the gist of what people were saying. Getting out of Isla Patrulla presented a problem, the bus that we came over in couldn't function and finally someone found a flatbed truck to haul the party out. We arrived back in Treinta y Tres pretty late and all of us slept on the benches in the chapel there. Elder Kimball, who was about sixty or so then didn't complain about the inconvenience at all, saying it was just one of those things a person has to have patience about.

Our children all attended school while we were in Uruguay. Gail and Patty went to a school called St. Catherine's, a private school run in the British style, with forms instead of grades. Ronnie attended the regular British School. The British were always pretty snobbish about their schools and weren't sure the American kids could hack it but interestingly enough all of our kids won the form prizes for academic excellence at end of the term. Gail turned eight years of age on June 30, 1959 and was baptized at Montevideo. Of course, this was in the middle of the Uruguayan winter, which was relatively mild, but the font in which she was baptized was only about three feet square and the water was deep and very cold. I just floated her on the water and then dunked her straight down to baptize her.

We had an opportunity in July 1959 to take a trip with the Jensens and their family to Paraguay where the Bob Wells' had been transferred. While there we went to see the world famous Iguazu Falls, located on the Parana River where Brazil, Paraguay and Argentina have common borders. In those days in order to get to Iguazu one had to travel on a bus from Asuncion through the jungle until you reached the Parana River. We then took a boat which looked like a whale boat with shallow sides over to the Brazil side of the river. This was winter time and we about froze at night

having to pile everything we could on the beds and sleep in our clothes. The Iguazu Falls are a tremendous sight, however, and it was worth all the trouble we had to take to get to see them. There was a border shack in Paraguay just before going down to board the boat to the Brazilian side and the "official" there wanted me to leave my passport with him until we returned, which I wasn't about to do, since diplomatic passports were known to disappear under such circumstances. He finally settled for my leaving something which he recognized, a Texaco credit card (which I knew had already expired).

I had thought of staying for two tours in Montevideo but Headquarters didn't think much of the idea so I received orders to return to Washington in November 1959. I did receive my promotion to GS-14 while in Montevideo so my career was continuing pretty well on track, a GS-14 being a rather senior grade, about the equivalent of a Colonel.

Prior to leaving Uruguay, however, we had a visit from another church dignitary, Harold B. Lee, one of the twelve apostles. We also had the Lees and the Jensens to our house for a special dinner. My colleague, Keith Schofield, and I were invited to a small luncheon which Ambassador Woodward hosted for Elder Lee. President Arthur Jensen was also one of the persons in attendance at that luncheon. There are some photographs of the group in our album for the year 1959. Prior to leaving Uruguay, Elder Lee bought a nutria fur coat for his wife's Christmas present and asked us to bring it back with us when we returned since we knew we would be visiting Utah on our home leave.

The Rodo Branch had a big despedida (farewell) for us before we left. The members of the branch had a special album with photos of all the organizations, Relief Society, Priesthood, etc, as well as the activities at the despedida itself. Many of the branch members signed the album with their expressions of thanks and love for the service we had rendered to the Uruguayan saints. One of the missionaries who signed the book was Dallas N. Archibald, who later was the mission president in the Seville Mission when Marion and I were there in 1982. We returned to the States on the same ship on which we had arrived, the S.S. Brasil, arriving in New York City in the pre-Christmas period and took the kids to Macy's before preceding on to Washington for a brief check in visit before going to California and Utah for home leave.